tioners gestured at a more fruitful way to fill the "vital gap": in 2012, the centrally-run Kendriya Vidyalaya schools had issued uniform guidelines where Muslim girls who so desired could wear a "grey-coloured headscarf, matching with the bottom wear, with a red hem". Why could the state not follow suit? Still, even if the idea that a headscarf could pose a law and order problem were to be offered seriously, the onus on the state would have been to quell it—not to victimise the scarf. Karnataka home minister Araga Dnyanendra, instead, was reported endorsing the de facto hijab ban with the line that schools and colleges must "inculcate Indian values". Unbeknownst to him perhaps, the Muslim wing of the RSS in MP had solved that particular conundrum, declaring the hijab to be "Indian attire".

The vital gap, of course, could lie elsewhere. What needs to be scrutinised is the act of the state and that of the institution in prescribing the uniform in the first place—whether access to education can be thus regulated. "The students are impugning those acts," says Alam, "they are not the ones who should be subjected to scrutiny." In the end, said another lawyer close to the petitioners, what could have been settled at a lower, lighter end of the scale—"as a purely administrative question"—has been taken to a zone that's "risky for the court, the communities involved, and the country itself, even if the court has been careful to delimit it strictly to the domain of the classroom, thus ringfencing it from loose interpretations of a wider ban".

Ground Zero Dark Thirty

A domino effect may be difficult to stop though—especially when more than one side seems to want it. A few decades ago, it might have beggared belief to imagine that, in 2022, Udupi would witness the spectacle of a slogan war between hijab-clad girls and saffron-shawled boys. But the ground for that had been created through assiduous efforts. Coastal Karnataka has been a wall-to-wall laboratory for Hindutva for long now, with many infamous incidents to its credit, and a matching communal upsurge from the other side. The Kerala-born Popular Front of India (PFI), whose Islamist radicalism has been the lightning rod for heated debates in recent years, was in the thick of action in the present controversy via affiliates like the Campus Front of India (CFI).

"These are actually two distinct movements, totally unconnected to each other at their core," says author and political commentator Shajahan Madampat. He sees the hijab affair as part of the newest strategy of the Hindutva project, its determination to erase all markers of Muslim identity and presence in India, after beef lynchings, CAA-NRC, changing the names of cities et al. That process of erasure, he says, is part of the Modi regime's policy and it is inappropriate to bring in other questions about the hijab into that frame: its desirability or otherwise, its orthodoxy. At the same time, he advocates a careful look at this region of Karnataka. "If you map the growth of Islamic puritanism across India, coastal Karnataka would be far ahead of any other region, with a much higher prevalence of phenomena like the face veil," he says. Talking of his native place, Malappuram, in Kerala, he says you see manifestations of orthodoxy there, not fanaticism. And contrasts it with Bhatkal, Karnataka, and its "terror" historysheet. "That's an integral part of the social churn going on across the Udupi coast," he says, "up to Kasaragod in Kerala, which has fed this game of competitive radicalisation." Ahammed Ashraf, an intellectual aligned with Islamic liberation theology, shares the disquiet—finding it difficult to endorse the response to the "cultural and political threat of Hindutva" from sections of Karnataka's

What Courts Have Said

In a recent interview, Supreme Court senior advocate Sanjay Hegde noted that there is no clear precedent on whether girls can wear *hijab*s in classrooms because there is no legislation on this specific issue. He also highlighted that past rulings by various courts are specific to the context of the petitions they were hearing, and that finding a middle ground between individual and institutional rights is a constant balancing act. A list of rulings...

